PERSONAL TRAVEL DOSSIER · PREPARED 20 OCTOBER 2026

Vietnam & Laos Grand Itinerary

Hanoi · Ha Long Bay · Sapa → Luang Prabang · Vang Vieng · Vientiane → Doha

17 days, 16 nights. Arrive Hanoi (HAN) Friday 4 December 2026, 21:00. Depart Vientiane (VTE) Sunday 20 December 2026 on your booked Vientiane–Doha ticket. Everything below is sequenced day-by-day, with transport times, prices, visas, booking deadlines and on-the-ground detail.

Fri 4 Dec → Sun 20 Dec 2026

6 cities · 2 countries

Route: HAN · HLG · Sapa · LPQ · VV · VTE · DOH

Peak dry season — best weather window

01 · TRIP AT A GLANCE

Snapshot

Date	Leg	Highlights	Sleep
Fri 4 Dec	Arrive Hanoi 21:00	Old Quarter arrival, late pho	Hanoi
Sat 5 Dec	Hanoi full day	Hoan Kiem, Temple of Literature, Ho Chi Minh complex, Train Street, water puppets, egg coffee	Hanoi
Sun 6 Dec	Ninh Binh day trip	Trang An sampan, Mua Cave 500 steps, Hoa Lu, Bai Dinh Pagoda	Hanoi
Mon 7 Dec	Ha Long Bay overnight cruise	Sung Sot Cave, Titop Island, kayaking, sunset cooking class	On board
Tue 8 Dec	Cruise → Hanoi → night train	Back by ~15:30; SP night train 21:45 to Lao Cai	Sleeper train
Wed 9 Dec	Sapa	Arrive 05:20, Cat Cat / Lao Chai–Ta Van trek, mountain views	Sapa
Thu 10 Dec	Sapa → Hanoi	Fansipan cable car or Ham Rong; limousine van to Hanoi	Hanoi

Fri 11 Dec	Fly Hanoi → Luang Prabang	VN931 13:10→14:15; Mekong dusk, Mount Phousi sunset	Luang Prabang
Sat 12 Dec	Luang Prabang nature	Kuang Si Falls turquoise pools + Pak Ou caves by boat	Luang Prabang
Sun 13 Dec	Luang Prabang culture	5:30 monk alms (Sunday = main procession), Royal Palace, morning market	Luang Prabang
Mon 14 Dec	Train to Vang Vieng	C95 09:48→10:42; Blue Lagoon 3, Tham Chang cave, Nam Song sunset	Vang Vieng
Tue 15 Dec	Vang Vieng → Vientiane	Morning tubing/kayak; D87 15:52→16:44; night market	Vientiane
Wed 16 Dec	Vientiane monuments	Pha That Luang, Patuxai, COPE, Kualao Lao dance dinner	Vientiane
Thu 17 Dec	Buddha Park & Mekong	Xieng Khuan sculptures, Talat Sao, Mekong riverside sunset	Vientiane
Fri 18 Dec	Slow Vientiane day	Morning alms viewing, Lao massage, shopping, optional Nam Ngum	Vientiane
Sat 19 Dec	Last full day	That Luang revisit, coffee, packing, farewell khao soi	Vientiane
Sun 20 Dec	Depart Vientiane → Doha	Wattay Airport, morning at leisure per your flight time	✈ Home

> **Golden thread:** Imperial Vietnam (Hanoi) → UNESCO karst (Ha Long) → cloud-forest terraces (Sapa) → royal Buddhist Laos (Luang Prabang) → karst adventure valley (Vang Vieng) → Mekong capital (Vientiane) → Doha.

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02 · FROM TODAY (20 OCT 2026) TO DEPARTURE

Pre-Trip Countdown — Do These Now

Today is **Tuesday 20 October 2026**. You have **45 days**. Work down this list in order; deadlines are real (railway tickets and e-visas are the two things that actually sell out / process slowly).

When	Task	Detail / link
Today–Thu 22 Oct	**Apply for Vietnam e-Visa**	Official portal only: **evisa.gov.vn** · $25 single-entry / $50 multi-entry · 90-day validity · 3–5 working days (apply early; fee non-refundable). Need: passport scan + 4×6 cm white-bg photo (no glasses), entry = Noi Bai (HAN). Print 2 copies.
This week	**Book Hanoi → Luang Prabang flight**	Fri 11 Dec: **VN931, Vietnam Airlines, 13:10 HAN → 14:15 LPQ**, ~1h05, A321 (also Lao Airlines QV314 evening option 19:10→20:20). ~$130–250 one-way. Book on vietnamairlines.com or your OTA. Only ~5 nonstops/week — do not delay.
This week	**Book Ha Long Bay cruise (2D1N)**	Mon 7 Dec embark. 4-star from ~$139–190 pp all-inclusive (e.g., Cozy Bay Grand, Le Journey, Arcady) incl. Hanoi transfers, cabin, 4 meals, kayaking, Sung Sot + Titop. Book direct or via GetYourGuide/Viator with free cancellation.
This week	**Book Sapa night train (Tue 8 Dec)**	Hanoi → Lao Cai sleeper. Recommend **SP15 21:45→05:20** or SP1 21:35→05:30. 4-berth soft sleeper ≈ 450,000–630,000 VND; private tourist cabin (Chapa/Sapaly) $45–65. Book via dsvn.vn (Vietnamese, finicky cards) or easier: 12Go/Baolau/your hotel agent. **Dec 8 is a Tuesday — moderate demand, but book 2+ weeks ahead.**
This week	**Book hotels**	Free-cancellation rates for: Hanoi Old Quarter ×3 nights (4,5,6 Dec), Hanoi 1 night (10 Dec), Sapa (9 Dec), Luang Prabang ×3 (11–13 Dec), Vang Vieng (14 Dec), Vientiane ×4 (15–18 Dec) + (19 Dec). See Section 07 for areas & picks.
Early Nov	**Book Ninh Binh day trip**	Sun 6 Dec: Trang An + Mua Cave + Hoa Lu (~$40–55 pp incl. lunch & transfers) on GetYourGuide/YourGuide, or DIY bus from Hanoi Giap Bat (~2h, ~120,000 VND).
Mid Nov (after ~10 Nov)	**Apply Laos e-Visa**	Official portal: **laoevisa.gov.la** · Tourist T-B3 · $50 + ~$1.75 card fee · 3 working days · valid for entry at **Luang Prabang Airport (LPQ)** ✓. Alternative: Visa on Arrival at LPQ, $40 exact USD cash + 1 photo + LDIF arrival form (free, online). Both give 30 days.

Mid Nov	**Book Kuang Si + Pak Ou tour**	Sat 12 Dec shared minivan day tour from LPB ~$35–50 pp, or DIY: songthaew to Kuang Si (~$6 pp return), boat to Pak Ou (~$15–25).
~1 Dec	**Book Laos-China Railway tickets**	Seats release only **6 days ahead at 06:30** Vientiane time. Book online via Baolau/12Go/YesMyTrips the moment they open: **Mon 14 Dec: C95 09:48 LPQ→VV 10:42** (~$11–15). Then on **1 Dec morning book Tue 15 Dec: D87 VV 15:52→VTE 16:44** (~$13–17). Passport name required.
Early Dec	**Cash & cards**	Get clean **$100–200 in crisp USD notes** (for Laos VOA if used, exchanging, tips). ATMs plentiful in Hanoi/LPB/Vientiane. Notify your bank. Carry 2 cards on separate pockets.
Early Dec	**eSIM / insurance / prints**	Regional eSIM (Airalo/Holafly) or Viettel (Vietnam) + Unitel (Laos). Travel insurance incl. medical evacuation. Print: e-visas, flight tickets, hotel vouchers, cruise & train bookings — one paper set + offline PDFs.
Sat 3 Dec	**Final 24h checklist**	Passport (6+ months validity, 2 blank pages) · power banks out of checked bag · Vietnam plug types A/B/C (220V) and Laos C/E (220V) · wear layers for the 21:00 Hanoi landing (14–18°C) · download offline Google Maps for Hanoi/Ha Long/Sapa/LPB/VV/VTE.

Critical path: Vietnam e-visa (3–5 days), HAN→LPQ flight (limited nonstops), Ha Long cruise (Dec sells out), night train cabins, and the 6-day LCR railway window. Everything else is flexible.

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03 · ENTRY DOCUMENTS

Visas & Border Formalities

🇻🇳 Vietnam — e-Visa

- Apply: **evisa.gov.vn** (official Immigration Dept portal)
- Fee: **$25** single entry · **$50** multiple entry
- Validity: up to **90 days**, single or multiple entry — covers your whole stay
- Processing: typically **3–5 working days** (some same-week; fee non-refundable if rejected)
- Entry port: **Noi Bai International (HAN), Hanoi**
- Docs: passport bio scan + 4×6 cm photo (white bg, no glasses), hotel address, onward ticket
- Carry: **2 printed colour copies** + digital copy

🇱🇦 Laos — e-Visa or Visa on Arrival

- Option A — e-Visa: **laoevisa.gov.la** (MOFA official) · Tourist **T-B3** · **$50** + ~$1.75 · 3 working days · **valid at LPQ airport ✓**
- Option B — Visa on Arrival at **Luang Prabang Airport**: **$40 exact cash USD** + 1 passport photo + filled form; 15–30 min; +$1–2 "overtime" fee possible (your flight lands 14:15 — normal hours)
- Both grant **30 days single entry** — plenty for 9 nights
- Before landing, fill the free **LDIF arrival card** online (QR given on aircraft/immigration desks)
- Passport: 6+ months validity, 2 blank pages; carry hotel printout + your Vientiane–Doha onward ticket
- Beware lookalike visa sites charging $90–130 — only the two official domains above

No other visas needed: your Hanoi→Luang Prabang flight is a simple international departure from HAN T2 + arrival at LPQ; the Vientiane→Doha flight departs Wattay. No Vietnam exit visa, no transit visas on any routing via BKK/CAN/SIN.

Rules verified against official portals, October 2026. If your passport is not on the e-Visa eligibility list, use embassy sticker visas — allow 2 weeks. Requirements are quoted for the common case (e.g., Indian/other passports needing both visas); visa-exempt nationalities (13 listed by Vietnam, incl. Japan, Korea, UK, EU Schengen states, etc. — 45-day Vietnam stay; several ASEAN passports) should still verify on the portals.

04 · THE SHAPE OF THE TRIP

Route Overview

Direction: deep-north Vietnam first (arrival side), then a short hop into northern Laos, drifting south down the Laos–China railway spine to the capital, and out to Doha.

Segment	Mode	Duration	Cost (pp approx)	Notes
HAN airport → Old Quarter	Grab / taxi	45–60 min	350,000–450,000 VND	Or bus 86, ~50,000 VND

Hanoi → Ninh Binh (day)	Tour minivan	2.5 h each way	incl. in tour $40–55	Trang An, Mua Cave, Hoa Lu
Hanoi → Ha Long cruise	Limousine + boat	3.5 h + cruise	$139–190 all-in	2D1N on board
Hanoi → Lao Cai (Sapa)	Night train SP15/SP1	~7.7 h	$18–65	21:45→05:20; +1 h road to Sapa
Sapa → Hanoi	Limousine van	5–5.5 h	$15–25	Or SP8 day train 12:05→19:30
Hanoi → Luang Prabang	VN931 flight	1 h 05	$130–250	13:10→14:15, Fri 11 Dec
Luang Prabang → Vang Vieng	LCR train C95	54 min	from $11	09:48→10:42, Mon 14 Dec
Vang Vieng → Vientiane	LCR train D87	52 min	from $13	15:52→16:44, Tue 15 Dec
Vientiane → Doha	Your booked ticket	~7 h direct or 10–14 h via BKK/HAN	booked	Wattay (VTE) → Hamad (DOH)

> **Altitude & climate arc:** Hanoi 15 m (14–22°C, dry winter) → Ha Long sea level (misty karsts) → Sapa 1,600 m (8–16°C, cold dawn, possible fog/hoar frost) → LPB 305 m → Vang Vieng 580 m → Vientiane 170 m (dry season 18–31°C, warm afternoons, cool river evenings).

Itinerary, 4–20 December 2026

Day 0 · Fri 20 Oct → Fri 3 Dec — Countdown (see Section 02)

Home base: Doha

Today kicks off the booking sprint: Vietnam e-visa, HAN→LPQ flight, Ha Long cruise, Sapa night train, hotels — then Laos e-visa mid-November and the railway tickets in early December. By 3 Dec every voucher should be printed and your USD cash sorted.

Day 1 · Fri 4 Dec — Arrive Hanoi, 21:00

Sleep: Old Quarter

21:00 Land at **Noi Bai International (HAN)**. Immigration: passport + printed e-visa (30–45 min at this hour), baggage, SIM/eSIM already active.

21:50 **Transfer to Old Quarter:** Grab app (cheapest, ~400,000 VND) or official airport taxi queue (~450,000 VND). 45–60 min night drive through Hanoi's ring roads. Pre-book a hotel pickup (~$18–25) if you prefer zero hassle after the long-haul.

23:00 Check in (pre-arranged late check-in; most Old Quarter hotels hold your room all night). Drop bags, change out of travel clothes.

23:15 **Late dinner** — you land hungry. Walk to **Phở Gia Truyền** (49 Bát Đàn) if still serving, or any 24h phở stall around Tô Tịch / Hàng Bài: steaming bowl of phở bò (beef phở) or bún chả if open. Alternatively hotel-area banh mi + iced coffee.

Hanoi in December is 14–22°C at night — bring a light jacket out of your daypack, not from the suitcase.

Day 2 · Sat 5 Dec — Hanoi Grand Tour

Sleep: Hanoi · Meals: street food

07:00	**Breakfast: bánh cuốn** (steamed rice rolls) at 14 Hàng Gà, or bún riêu crab noodle soup. Coffee: **egg coffee (cà phê trứng)** at Café Giảng (39 Nguyễn Hữu Huân) — the original.
08:30	**Hoàn Kiếm Lake & Ngọc Sơn Temple** — cross the red Huc Bridge to the island temple; 30 min. Walk the lake's northern edge via Hàng Đào.
09:30	**Temple of Literature (Văn Miếu)** — Vietnam's first university, 1070 AD; serene courtyards. ~30 min by foot/cyclo, 30,000 VND entry. (Closed Mon & Fri mornings for ceremonies sometimes — today is Saturday ✓.)
11:00	**Ho Chi Minh Complex** — Mausoleum (closed Mon & Fri; Sat ok — queue by 10:45, no photos inside, shorts forbidden), One-Pillar Pagoda, Presidential Palace grounds, Ho Chi Minh Museum. Free entry, passport required. Dress shoulders/knees covered.
13:00	**Lunch: bún chả** (grill-your-own pork patties + noodles) at Bún Chả Hương Liên (24 Lê Văn Hưu — the Obama-bun cha place) or chả cá fish hotpot on Chả Cá street.
14:30	**Old Quarter lanes walk** — 36 streets each named after a trade (Hàng Bạc silver, Hàng Gai silk). **St. Joseph's Cathedral**, **Đồng Xuân market**, water-puppet craft shops.
16:00	**Hanoi Train Street** — the famous narrow alley on Nguyễn Công Trứ / Phung Hung where the train passes between houses. Go late afternoon for the 15:15/17:00-ish passes; buy a café seat (coffee ~40,000 VND) and stand clear when the horn sounds. (Access rules change — if barriers block the classic spot, the Phung Hung mural street cafés still have views.)
18:00	**Water puppet show** — Thăng Long Water Puppet Theatre, 57B Đinh Tiên Hoàng, tickets ~100,000 VND, shows hourly 18:00–21:00. 50 min of lacquered ducks, dragons and folk music on the pond stage.
19:30	**Dinner crawl**: **bánh xèo** sizzling crepes (172 Đội Cấn), **phở gà** at Phở Thìn 13 Lò Đúc, then bia hơi (draft beer) at Bia Hoi Junction (Tạ Hiện) — the world's cheapest fresh beer, ~10,000 VND a glass.

Budget the day: entries ~150,000 VND + food ~250,000 VND + cyclo/Grab ~100,000 VND ≈ $20 pp.

Day 3 · Sun 6 Dec — Ninh Binh Day Trip ("Ha Long Bay on land")

Sleep: Hanoi · Booked tour

08:00	Pick-up from Old Quarter hotel by minivan (~2.5 h drive, 100 km south; comfort stop en route).
10:30	**Tràng An** — sampan rowed by locals through karst caves and flooded valleys (2 h loop, three grottoes, ~200,000 VND entry incl. boat). The Dec light on the lime cliffs is superb. Sit left for cave entries.
12:30	**Lunch** — included in most tours: goat meat (dê), crispy rice, local greens at a Tam Coc / Ninh Binh village restaurant.
13:30	**Mua Cave (Hang Múa)** — 500 stone steps to the ridge viewpoint over Tam Coc's rice paddies and river: the iconic photo of the trip. Water + shoes with grip.
15:00	**Hoa Lu ancient capital** — 10th-century temples of kings Đinh & Lê, set against cliffs. Short walk, 30 min.
16:00	Optional **Bai Dinh Pagoda** — Vietnam's largest Buddhist complex (electric car ride across the hillside).
18:30	Back in Hanoi. **Dinner:** chả cá or a bowl of bún bò Nam Bộ near your hotel. Early night — cruise pickup is early.

DIY version: bus from Giáp Nhập station to Ninh Bình (~2 h, 120,000 VND), then hire a motorbike driver locally for the loop (~300,000–500,000 VND/day). Tour is easier and only marginally pricier.

Day 4 · Mon 7 Dec — Ha Long Bay Overnight Cruise

Sleep: On board

07:30	Hotel pick-up (Old Quarter meeting points 07:15–08:00) — limousine/minivan ~3.5 h via the new expressway to Tuan Chau Marina.
11:30	Arrive marina, check-in lounge, then tender to your junk. Welcome drink, cabin assignment (book a **sea-view balcony cabin** if budget allows).
12:30	**Lunch onboard** as the boat cruises among 1,600+ limestone islands. Watch for Dog Stone Islet, Fighting Cock Islet.
14:30	**Sung Sot (Surprise) Cave** — the bay's largest grotto; cathedral chambers of stalactites (climb ~100 steps). Then **Titop Island**: swim off the tiny beach or climb 420 steps to the 360° panorama viewpoint.
17:00	**Sunset party + Vietnamese cooking class** on the sundeck — learn fresh spring rolls as the sun drops behind karsts. Happy hour buy-2-get-1.
19:00	**Dinner onboard** (seafood set menu), then squid fishing from the stern, stargazing, or bar. Anchored overnight in a quiet lagoon.

December Ha Long is often **softly misty** — atmospheric, not a cancellation. Operators sail unless official storms; kayak/ swimming runs if seas are calm.

Day 5 · Tue 8 Dec — Cruise Finale → Night Train to Sapa

Sleep: Sleeper train SP15/SP1

06:00	Tai chi on the sundeck; coffee as the mist lifts off the bay.
07:00	Breakfast, then **Luon Cave** by kayak or bamboo boat through a hidden lagoon (monkeys on the walls). Some itineraries place Sung Sot/Titop on day 2 — either way you cover all three icons.
10:30	Brunch while cruising back to Tuan Chau; disembark ~11:30.
12:00	Limousine back to Hanoi — arrive **~15:30**. Collect the pre-booked night-train tickets from your hotel/agent (or e-ticket + passport).
16:00	Shower/refresh at hotel (use day-use room or late checkout booked for this date), last Hanoi stroll, pack daypack for Sapa. **Leave the big suitcase locked at the hotel** (most allow storage to 10 Dec).
19:45	Dinner near station: phở or cơm (rice set). Taxi to **Hanoi Railway Station** (Ga Hà Nội, 120 Lê Duẩn).
21:45	Board **SP15** (or SP1 21:35 — whichever you booked). 4-berth soft-sleeper cabin, AC, bedding provided. Lights out early: 4-berth lower bunk is easiest with luggage. ~7 h 40 min.

Private tourist wagons (Chapa Express, Sapaly) attach to SP trains — wood-panelled cabins, bottled water, better linen: worth the $20 upgrade for a night you actually need to sleep on.

Day 6 · Wed 9 Dec — Sapa: Terraces & Hill Tribes

Sleep: Sapa town

05:20 Arrive **Lao Cai station**. Pre-booked shuttle/minivan up the 38 km mountain road to Sapa town (50–60 min, ~60,000–150,000 VND shared, or taxi 300,000 VND). Dawn over the Hoàng Liên Sơn foothills if skies clear.

06:30 Early check-in or luggage room at hotel; hot shower + breakfast at the hotel (eggs, baguette — French colonial legacy — and strong local coffee).

08:30 Start the classic valley trek with a local H'mong or Red Dao guide (~$25–40 for a private/guide-day, or free-ish if you simply walk): **Cat Cat village** (waterfall, traditional houses, 30 min downhill) — or the richer full-day **Lao Chải → Tả Van** walk along terrace ridgelines down to the Muong Hoa valley (~4–5 h, easy-moderate, rice terraces at their post-harvest golden stubble in December).

12:30 **Lunch in Tả Van village** — bamboo-sticky rice, stream fish, thang co if you're adventurous (included on guided treks).

15:00 Continue/return to Sapa town by jeep. Browse **Sapa stone church** and the weekend-adjacent market streets; try thắng cố or a warm hotpot for dinner.

19:00 Early night — Sapa evenings in December drop to 5–10°C. Heated blanket + a rhum (corn whisky) nightcap.

Cold alert: Sapa Dec dawns can hit 4–8°C with fog or even frost on Fansipan. Layers, beanie, light gloves, proper shoes. Porters/guides can arrange rain ponchos cheaply.

Day 7 · Thu 10 Dec — Sapa Heights → Hanoi

Sleep: Hanoi

07:00 Choose your morning: **Fansipan cable car** to the 3,143 m "Roof of Indochina" summit (cable ~700,000 VND; go early for clear views above the cloud) — or the lighter **Ham Rong flower garden** walk right above town with valley panoramas.

11:00 Check out. Board the **limousine van** Sapa → Hanoi (Sapa Express / Green Bus / Good Morning Sapa — reclining 9-seat vans, ~$18–25, hotel pick-up, 5–5.5 h, rest stop). Alternative: day train SP8 12:05 Lao Cai → 19:30 Hanoi if you prefer rails.

16:30 Arrive Hanoi (hotel pick-up point). Reunite with the stored suitcase, laundry done, repack for Laos (lighter — LPB/VV/VTE are warm).

18:00 **Farewell-Vietnam evening:** sunset drink at a rooftop bar (Hanoi Social Club / The Summit), then **bún bò Huế** or a final bún chả + banh mi corner feast. Pack carry-on for tomorrow's flight: documents, meds, swimwear (Kuang Si!), powerbank.

Hotels will often keep your big bag free if you rebook the 10th night with them — ask at check-in on the 4th.

Day 8 · Fri 11 Dec — Fly to Luang Prabang, Sunset on the Mekong

Sleep: Luang Prabang

08:00	Slow morning; breakfast; **Grab to Noi Bai T2** (45 min — leave 3 h before departure for the international hop).
13:10	**VN931 Vietnam Airlines → Luang Prabang** (1 h 05, A321; Lao Airlines QV314 19:10 is the backup). Departure from Hanoi T2.
14:15	Land **LPQ airport**. Visa lane: e-Visa letter or VOA desk ($40 cash) — 15–30 min at this quiet airport, then luggage + customs.
15:15	Transfer to hotel (4 km to the peninsula; tuk-tuk/taxi ~50,000–80,000 LAK or pre-booked). Check in to your guesthouse on the Mekong/Khan side.
16:00	**Old town orientation walk**: Waten Street shophouses, **Wat Visoun** (Watermelon stupa), French colonial lanes. Snack: Lao coffee (pounded with a mortar — "coffee Lao") at a riverfront café.
17:15	**Mount Phousi (Phou Si)** — 328 steps for the classic sunset over the Mekong and Nam Khan confluence, golden light on Luang Prabang's rooftops and distant Mekong bends. (Entry 20,000 LAK; go up Phousi, down the other side to the night market.)
18:30	**Night market on Sisavangvong Road** — H'mong textiles, mulberry paper, riverweed crackers (kaipen). **Dinner:** barbecue street stalls — grilled fish in banana leaf, laap, sticky rice (khao niao) eaten with fingers.

You are now in Laos: kip (LAK) is the currency, ~21,000 = $1. ATMs on the main strip; USD cash widely accepted at better rates at banks/exchange shops.

Day 9 · Sat 12 Dec — Kuang Si Falls & Pak Ou Caves

Sleep: Luang Prabang · Full-day tour ~$35–50

08:00	Minivan pick-up. First stop: **Kuang Si Falls** (29 km, 45 min) — tiered turquoise pools spilling 60 m through jungle. Swim in the lower pools (bring swimsuit), climb to the top viewpoint, and visit the **Free the Bears rescue centre** at the entrance (included).
11:30	En route back: stop at a **Khamu/Lao village** and a rice-wine/whisky (lao-lao) tasting stall.
13:00	**Lunch** in town (often included), then board a **slow boat up the Mekong** (~2 h upstream past sandbanks and fishing rafts).
15:30	**Pak Ou Caves** — the river-cliff grottoes filled with thousands of small Buddha images left by pilgrims for centuries; two caves (lower: full of statues, upper: stalactites + a river view).
17:30	Return boat + van to LPB. **Dinner: buffet-Lao-style khantoke** or orlam stew at a local kitchen on the Khan; or French-Lao bistro (Luang Prabang has superb French bakeries — croissants for tomorrow's alms-adjacent breakfast).

Kuang Si is a national park — no swimwear above the 3rd pool; pay the small photo/camera fee if asked (10,000 LAK). Waters are genuinely cold in Dec; a quick dip is bracing, not long.

Day 10 · Sun 13 Dec — Sacred Luang Prabang (Alms Day Sunday)

Sleep: Luang Prabang

05:15	**Baci / quiet start** — walk to **Sakkaline Road** in silence by 05:30 for **binthabat (tak bat)**: the river of saffron-robed monks streaming past to collect sticky rice. Sunday is the main, longest procession. Buy a basket of rice (10,000–20,000 LAK) from a vendor; kneel, offer a small handful, don't touch the monks (women never touch). Watch only — no flash, no blocking.
06:30	Breakfast; back to hotel for proper sleep or keep going.
08:30	**Royal Palace Museum (Haw Kham)** — throne hall, the 16th-century Phra Bang Buddha image the city is named for, murals of Lao history. (Opens 08:00; dress respectfully.)
10:00	**Wat Xieng Thong** — the masterpiece temple of Laos: sweeping tiered roofs, gold-tree mosaic on the rear wall, the funeral carriage tower. The single must-see monument of the city.
11:00	**Traditional Arts & Ethnology Centre** (excellent small museum of hill-tribe textiles) or the **Buffalo Dairy** café for ethical elephant-free coffee & ice cream.
12:30	**Lunch: lao-lao sausage**, laap, som tam (green papaya salad) at a riverside kitchen.
14:00	**Weaving & craft lanes:** visit a H'mong weaving cooperative on the Khan (watch natural indigo & lotus-silk techniques), or take a short **cooking class** (market visit + 3 dishes, ~$30–45, ~3 h).
17:30	**Mekong sunset drink** at a river-bar, then **Bangkok-style street dinner**: grilled meats, khao piak sen (Lao chicken noodle soup). Early night — train tomorrow.

Day 11 · Mon 14 Dec — Laos–China Railway to Vang Vieng

Sleep: Vang Vieng

08:00	Check out, tuk-tuk to **Luang Prabang Railway Station** (13 km, ~25 min, 40,000–60,000 LAK — station is well outside town, not walkable). Luggage through security; be seated **30–60 min early**.
09:48	**Train C95 → Vang Vieng** (Lane Xang EMU, 2nd class ~$11–15). 54 minutes of pure karst theatre — viaducts, tunnels, rice valleys; sit on the **right (mountain) side** heading south.
10:42	Arrive **Vang Vieng station** (7 km from town). Songthaew/taxi to guesthouse (~20,000–30,000 LAK). Check in; leave bags.
12:00	**Lunch:** riverside restaurant on the Nam Song — pizza/smoothies (the backpacker classics) or Lao set. Rent a bicycle (~30,000 LAK/day) for the afternoon.
13:30	**Blue Lagoon 3** (10 km west) — the prettiest of the three lagoons: milky-turquoise water in a jungle bowl, rope swings, a short walk to **Tham Jung cave** (climb for a sky-hole view). Entry ~10,000 LAK.
16:30	Return; climb **Tham Chang cave** near town for the balcony view over the valley, or just drift on a bamboo tube in the river shallows.
17:45	**Sunset on the Nam Song** — the limestone wall behind town goes amber. Beer Lao on a deck chair.
19:00	**Dinner:** Vang Vieng main strip — try **buffalo tartare** (the local specialty) or happy-shake-free proper Lao food at a garden restaurant. Early night; tomorrow is a travel day but a short one.

Day 12 · Tue 15 Dec — Vang Vieng Morning → Train to Vientiane

Sleep: Vientiane

07:30	**Morning on the river:** choose one — **tubing the Nam Song** (float past caves and rope swings, ~2 h, ~55,000 LAK incl. tube), **kayaking** through the rapids section, or a **bike ride to the rice paddies** north of town with karst backdrop photos.
11:00	Shower, check out, lunch near the strip. **Book the songthaew to Vang Vieng station** for ~14:45 (7 km).
15:52	**Train D87 → Vientiane** (international CR200J Fuxing set, 2nd class ~$13). 52 minutes, then the Mekong plain opens up.
16:44	Arrive **Vientiane (Khamsavath) station**. Tuk-tuk/taxi to hotel in the riverfront/old-town area (~20–30 min, 60,000–100,000 LAK). Check in.
18:00	**Mekong riverside promenade** — the whole city walks here at dusk: street-food stalls, fruit shakes, the sun dropping toward Thailand across the river.
18:45	**Night market** opposite the river (handicrafts, textiles) → **dinner: khao soi luang prabang** (minced-pork noodle soup — different from the Thai version), grilled chicken, sticky rice. Beer Lao dark at a riverside bar.

Day 13 · Wed 16 Dec — Vientiane Monument Circuit

Sleep: Vientiane

08:00	Breakfast at hotel / **jeow bong** (buffalo-rind dip) with sticky rice at a local shop.
08:45	**Pha That Luang** — Laos' holiest monument, a gold-plated stupa over a 16th-century relic; go early for empty courtyards and best light. Free / 30,000 LAK for the museum. Dress covered.
10:15	**Hai An / That Luang surroundings:** walk to **Patuxai Victory Monument** (Laos' Arc de Triomphe — climb the interior stair for the city panorama, 5,000 LAK) through its weirdly wonderful mythological concrete reliefs.
11:30	**COPE Visitor Centre** — the essential, sobering museum on UXO (unexploded ordnance) in Laos, with a reconstructed bomb-shelter home and prosthetics workshop. ~$2, 1.5 h. Tuk-tuk ~15 min from centre.
13:30	**Lunch:** Lao-Italian or the excellent street food near **Talat Sao (Morning Market)**; browse the market's textile floors upstairs.
15:00	**Wat Si Saket** (thousands of tiny Buddholes in cloister niches) and **Wat Ho Phra Keo** (former royal temple, now a museum of sculpture).
18:00	**Cultural dinner: Kualao Restaurant** (Samsenthai) — Lao set banquet with traditional dance show from ~19:00 (reserve ahead, ~$15–25 pp). Or French-Lao fine dining on the river.

Vientiane is compact — the monument circuit is 3–4 km total. Tuk-tuks quote 30,000–50,000 LAK per hop; agree the fare before hopping in. Grab coverage is thin; use hotel-arranged rides.

Day 14 · Thu 17 Dec — Buddha Park & Mekong Slow Life

Sleep: Vientiane

08:30 **Buddha Park (Xieng Khuan)** — 25 km east on the Mekong bank: a surreal 1958 sculpture field of 200+ Buddhist and Hindu figures — a giant reclining Buddha, a demonic "Hell Gate" pumpkin tower you climb through scenes of heaven and hell. Tuk-tuk round trip ~250,000–350,000 LAK (share with other guests), or local bus 44 from the Northern Bus Terminal, 5,000 LAK. Entry 15,000 LAK. ~2 h there.

11:30 On the way back, stop at **Nam Ngum Dam** viewpoint area, or simply return to town.

13:00 **Lunch + Talat Sao deep-dive** — the real market: coffee sacks, hill-tribe silver, silk sinh skirts, and the best Lao coffee beans (~50,000 LAK/250 g) to take home.

15:00 **Lao massage** (oil or dry, 1 h ≈ 80,000–120,000 LAK) — the traditional style is firmer and more stretching than Thai; excellent after 14 days of walking.

17:00 **Sunset boat on the Mekong** — short sampan cruise from the Chao Anouvong park jetty (~$8–12, 45 min) watching the Thai bank light up. Alternative: climb **Phu Chai or the park hill**… better: rooftop bar at your hotel with a Beer Lao.

19:00 **Dinner: orm-lam** (smoky Lao lamb-rib stew) at a riverside restaurant, then a last wander of the promenade. Video-call home — the next two days are soft.

Day 15 · Fri 18 Dec — Slow Day: Rituals, Shopping, Reserve Time

Sleep: Vientiane

06:30 Optional: **observe (not join) morning alms** on the quiet lanes behind Wat Si Saket — smaller and more intimate than Luang Prabang's. Then coffee at **Joma / Bean Café** (Vientiane's best café culture).

09:30 **Reserve slot A:** Full-day **Nam Ngum Dam & island lunch** trip (dam, reservoir boat, grilled fish lunch, ~$30–40 by charter/shared van) — OR — **Reserve slot B:** slow local day: **That Dam (Black Stupa)**, French colonial Indochina-style villas on Rue Setthathirath, **Axe Music/ bookshops**, stationery and silk hunting.

13:00 Lunch. Try **ping kai** (Lao grilled chicken) with jaew dipping sauces at a courtyard restaurant.

15:00 **Souvenir run:** Lao coffee + whiskey-lao + sinh textiles + mulberry paper cards from Talat Sao or the Hmong market stalls on the riverfront. Ship nothing heavy — carry-on it home.

17:30 **Final Mekong sunset sit** — the ritual of the trip: shake, sticky rice, watching the boats. Then pack properly for the flight (see Section 09 checklist).

Keep ~$50–80 in USD cash and enough kip for the airport taxi tomorrow; exchange leftover VND at banks (airport rates are poor).

Day 16 · Sat 19 Dec — Last Full Day in Laos

Sleep: Vientiane

09:00	**Luang Prabang-style indulgence, Vientiane edition:** revisit your favourite café; or the **Lao Textile Museum** (hand-loomed silks, ~100,000 LAK); or a final 90-min massage.
11:00	**Pha That Luang revisited at golden hour of day** — or the quiet alternative **Simuong temple** and the stupa's side lanes. Photos without crowds.
12:30	**Farewell lunch:** sit-down Lao tasting menu — laap, tam mak hoong, orlam, khao niao, and a Lao coffee flan. Toast the trip.
14:30	**Packing & admin:** final bag weigh-in, hand-wash pickup, e-ticket & passport photocopies, download offline maps for Doha arrival, message airline for meal/s seats if needed.
16:00	**Chao Anouvong Park stroll** — riverfront gardens with views to Thailand; the fountain show at dusk if scheduled.
18:30	**Easy dinner** near hotel: fried river fish, som tam, and an early night — especially if your Doha flight is morning; if it's evening, enjoy a longer final night.

Hotel tip: ask for late check-out (14:00) or day-use room for tomorrow; most Vientiane hotels are generous about storing luggage all day free.

Day 17 · Sun 20 Dec — Vientiane → Doha

✈ On your booked ticket

Morning	Per your ticket's departure time. Typical patterns on this route (verify against your booking): via Bangkok on Lao Airlines + Qatar Airways (e.g., QV445 18:10 → QR833 → DOH ~23:55 same day, ~10 h total), via Hanoi on QV311 + QR977, or a Qatar Airways service. **If late-evening departure:** keep the day: morning coffee, park, massage, lunch. **If afternoon departure:** leave the hotel by T−3 h.
T−3 h	**Transfer to Wattay International (VTE)** — 3 km from the centre, taxi 80,000–120,000 LAK (~$5–8), 15–25 min. Check in: passport, Laos exit stamp, boarding pass. Security is quick at this small airport.
In flight	~7 h 20 direct to Doha, or 10–14 h with one stop. Qatar Airways legs include meals; kip can't be spent airside — finish the cash or keep it for next time (Laos re-entry easy).
Arrival DOH	Hamad International: immigration + baggage, then home. Trip complete: **17 days, 2 countries, 6 bases, 4 UNESCO/World-Heritage-grade sites (Ha Long Bay, Luang Prabang town, Pha That Luang, Hanoi's old quarter spirit).**

Keep your Vietnam e-visa and Lao entry stamp pages photographed — useful for future visa applications and expense claims.

Transport Reference Tables

✈ Key flights

Flight	Route	Departs	Arrives	Days	Notes
VN931 (Vietnam Airlines)	HAN → LPQ	13:10	14:15	Mon, Wed, Thu, Fri, Sat	**Your Fri 11 Dec leg** · A321 · ~1h05
QV314 (Lao Airlines)	HAN → LPQ	19:10	20:20	Daily (typically)	Evening backup option
Vietnam/Lao Airlines	LPQ → HAN	—	—	daily-ish	Only needed if plans change
QV445 + QR833	VTE → BKK → DOH	18:10	23:55	select days	Classic Qatar connect, arrives same day
QV311 + QR977	VTE → HAN → DOH	14:40	23:10	select days	1-stop via Hanoi
QR (direct, where operated)	VTE → DOH	varies	~7 h later	select days	Check your ticket for QR97x series

Vientiane–Doha fares from ~$630 return-equivalent; your ticket is already issued. Flight times shown are representative 2026 schedules — always trust your booking confirmation over any timetable.

🚂 Hanoi ↔ Lao Cai (Sapa) — night trains, Tue 8 Dec / return

Train	Hanoi → Lao Cai	Lao Cai → Hanoi	4-berth soft sleeper	Private cabin (Chapa/Sapaly)
SP15 / SP1	21:45 / 21:35 → 05:20 / 05:30	—	~450,000–630,000 VND	$45–65
SP3	22:00 → 05:50	—	~510,000–650,000 VND	$45–65
SP7	22:40 → 06:27	—	~490,000–620,000 VND	—
SP8 (day)	—	12:05 → 19:30	~250,000–315,000 VND	—
SP2 / SP4	—	20:55 / 21:50 → 04:45 / 05:40	~400,000+ VND	option

Lao Cai → Sapa town: 35–38 km, 45–60 min. Shared shuttle 60,000–80,000 VND (wait outside arrivals), taxi 200,000–300,000 VND, pre-booked van $8–12. Book at **dsvn.vn**, 12Go, Baolau or via hotel — passport required at boarding.

🚄 Laos–China Railway — Luang Prabang ↔ Vang Vieng ↔ Vientiane (2026)

Train	LPQ → VV	VV → VTE	Duration	Fare (2nd class, from)	Use on this trip
C95	09:48 → 10:42	10:46 → 11:47	~54 min	$11–15	**Mon 14 Dec: LPQ → VV**
C91	12:28 → 13:34	13:38 → 14:31	~1 h 06	$11–17	Afternoon alternative
D87	14:58 → 15:49	15:52 → 16:44	~51–52 min	$13–17	**Tue 15 Dec: VV → VTE**
K11 (slow)	16:31 → 18:00	18:06 → 19:25	~1 h 20	$9–23 hard seat	Budget fallback
D83	18:11 → 19:02	19:06 → 19:59	~51–53 min	$13–17	Evening fallback
C85	18:35 → 19:31	19:35 → 20:28	~53–56 min	$11–15	Evening fallback

LCR rules that trip people up: tickets open **only 6 days ahead, 06:30 Vientiane time**, sold via LCR app (needs a Lao phone number — so use **Baolau / 12Go / YesMyTrips** agents or station counters in central LPB & Vientiane Center). Name must match passport exactly. Arrive **60–90 min early**: station security + passport check before boarding. Trains do not wait.

🚕 Local transfers — quick fares

Transfer	Mode	Fare	Time
Noi Bai → Hanoi Old Quarter	Grab/taxi · bus 86	350–450k VND · ~50k VND	45–60 min
Hanoi station ↔ hotel	Grab	50–100k VND	10–20 min
Lao Cai → Sapa	shuttle / taxi	60–80k · 200–300k VND	45–60 min
LPQ airport → old town	tuk-tuk	50–80k LAK	15–20 min
LPB town → railway station	tuk-tuk	40–60k LAK	25–30 min (13 km!)
VV station ↔ town	songthaew	20–30k LAK	15–20 min
Vientiane station → riverfront	tuk-tuk	60–100k LAK	20–30 min
Vientiane → Wattay airport	taxi	80–120k LAK	15–25 min

07 · BEDS & BOWLS

Where to Stay & What to Eat

🏨 Accommodation strategy (book free-cancellation now)

Base	Nights	Stay in	Example picks (any booking site)	Budget / mid / treat
Hanoi	4, 5, 6 + 10 Dec	Old Quarter (Hoàn Kiếm) — walk-to-everything	Budget: Nexy Hostel, Memory Hostel · Mid: La Siesta Premium, Silk Path Grand · Treat: Sofitel Legend Metropole	$15 / $45 / $180+
Sapa	9 Dec	Sapa town centre (near stone church)	Cat Cat View, Pao's Sapa Leisure, Hotel de la Coupole–MGallery	$20 / $70 / $180
Luang Prabang	11, 12, 13 Dec	Old peninsula, Khan river side (walk to night market & Phousi)	My Dream, Mano · Dalat Luxury, Saffron · Burasari Heritage, Avani+ (pool!)	$25 / $80 / $200
Vang Vieng	14 Dec	Nam Song riverside strip	Nana Backpackers (party) vs. Vang Vieng Rock View / Inthira (chill)	$12 / $45 / $120
Vientiane	15, 16, 17, 18 (+19)	Riverfront / Chao Anouvong / Setthathirath Rd	Family, City Inn · Ansara, Lao Orchid · Mercure, Settha Palace (heritage)	$25 / $70 / $150

Everywhere: book **free-cancellation** now, re-confirm best rates in November. Hotels hold luggage free on travel days — standard practice.

🍜 Eat-this list

Vietnam — must-haves

- **Phở bò** — Gia Truyền (49 Bát Đàn), Hanoi
- **Bún chả** — Hương Liên (24 Lê Văn Hưu)
- **Cà phê trứng** — Café Giảng (39 Nguyễn Hữu Huân)
- **Bánh cuốn** — 14 Hàng Gà
- **Bún bò Huế** — anywhere, spicy beef noodle
- **Bia hơi** — Tạ Hiện junction, 10k VND
- Sapa: **thắng cố**, corn wine; Ninh Bình: **dê** (goat)
- Ha Long: fresh seafood on board

Laos — must-haves

- **Khao niao** — sticky rice, the Lao staple, eat with fingers
- **Laap** — the national minced-meat "salad"
- **Orm lam** — smoky lamb-rib stew (Vientiane)
- **Khao soi Lao** — minced pork noodle soup (not Thai)
- **Tam mak hoong** — spicy green papaya salad
- **Kaipen** — fried riverweed with sesame (LPB snack)
- **Coffee Lao** + Lao whisky (lao-lao), Beer Lao everywhere
- LPB: French bakeries — croissants by the Mekong

Indicative Budget (per person, mid-range)

Category	Low	Mid	Comfort	Notes
Visas (VN + LA)	$65	$90	$90	VN e-visa $25–50; LA e-visa $52 or VOA $40
Internal flights (HAN→LPQ)	$130	$180	$280	Only one internal flight on this itinerary
Halong cruise 2D1N	$130	$160	$280	All-inclusive incl. transfers & meals
Night train HAN↔Lao Cai	$40	$55	$110	Return 4-berth or private cabin
Laos trains (LPQ-VV-VTE)	$22	$30	$50	2nd → 1st class
Hotels (16 nights, shared twin)	$350	$700	$1,400	Per-person share of mid rooms
Food & drink (17 days)	$170	$280	$450	$10 / $16 / $26 per day
Tours & entries	$120	$180	$280	Ninh Binh, Kuang Si+Pak Ou, Buddha Park, COPE, Phousi, cables, massages
Local transfers & tuk-tuks	$60	$100	$160	
eSIMs + insurance	$30	$60	$120	Insurance highly recommended
TOTAL (excl. Doha flights)	**~$1,120**	**~$1,835**	**~$3,220**	International air already booked

Currency cheat-sheet: 1 USD ≈ 25,500 VND · ≈ 21,000 LAK (Oct 2026 ballpark — check day-of). ATMs: BIDV/VTB/Vietcombank (VN), BCEL/ST Bank (LA); typical withdrawal fee $1–3 + your bank's. Cards work in hotels/upmarket restaurants; **street food, markets, tuk-tuks and trains = cash**. Carry small VND/LAK notes; USD crisp and unmarked for Laos.

Practical Kit

🎒 Packing for this exact trip

- Layer system for Hanoi/Sapa: base layers + mid fleece + windproof shell; beanie + gloves for Sapa dawn (4–8°C)
- Light long-sleeves + trousers for temple visits (That Luang, mausoleum, Wat Xieng Thong)
- Swimwear (Kuang Si, Titop, Vang Vieng lagoons) + quick-dry towel
- Broken-in trekking shoes/sneakers + flip-flops for guesthouses
- Power bank, universal adapter (VN types A/B/C; LA type C/E; both 220V)
- Reusable water bottle (refill at hotels — plastic is a real problem in Laos)
- Sun cream, insect repellent, basic meds (Imodium, rehydration salts, band-aids)
- Passport photos ×4 (VOA backup), photocopies of passport + visas
- Packable daypack for Sapa trek & day tours

📱 Connectivity & apps

- **eSIM:** Airalo/Holafly regional Asia plan, or Viettel tourist SIM at HAN (~$10, best Sapa/Halong coverage) + Unitel at LPQ (~$5)
- **Grab** — taxis & food in Vietnam; limited/no coverage in Laos (use hotel-arranged tuk-tuks)
- **Offline:** Google Maps downloads for each city; Google Translate Lao + Vietnamese packs
- **Booking:** Booking/Agoda (hotels), 12Go/Baolau (trains, buses), GetYourGuide (tours), Klook (Vietnam attractions)
- Messenger/WhatsApp — default for tour operators in both countries

🩺 Health & safety

- Travel insurance with medical evacuation — carry the policy number paper + app
- Tap water: not for drinking; bottled/filtered is cheap everywhere (refill where possible)
- Street-food rule: eat where queues of locals are; hot & freshly cooked = fine
- Sapa trek poles help on the Mua Cave steps and terrace paths
- Ha Long: use provided life jackets on kayaks/tenders; seas are calm in Dec
- December fog on Sapa/Ha Long roads — book transfers with established operators
- Check your routine vaccines are current (Hep A, typhoid recommended by most advisories)

☎ Numbers & etiquette

- Emergency VN: police **113** · fire **114** · ambulance **115**
- Emergency LA: police **191** · ambulance **195** · fire **190**
- Tourist police Hanoi: 024 3939 1457 · Vietnam e-visa help on evisa.gov.vn
- **Temple etiquette:** remove shoes, cover shoulders/knees, never point feet at Buddha, ask before photographing people
- **Alms in Luang Prabang:** observe silently; don't stand over the monks, no flash, no touch (men only offer)
- Bargain markets gently with a smile; round up fares kindly — small money matters more to them than you
- Photography of military/police/border = never

🧳 Final-24-hours checklist (Sat 3 Dec / travel days)

✔	Item	Detail
☐	Documents wallet	Passport · VN e-visa print ×2 · LA e-visa or $40 cash + photo · all tickets/vouchers paper + offline PDF
☐	Cash split	USD $100–200 crisp · VND ~2,000,000 · kip exchanged on arrival · cards in two separate bags
☐	Electronics	Phone + charger + power bank (hand luggage) + adapter + headphones
☐	Weather kit	Jacket for Hanoi landing · swimsuit for Kuang Si · sunhat for Vang Vieng
☐	Home logistics	Notify bank · airport parking/ride booked · house/pet cover · Doha arrival pickup

That's the whole dossier. Follow the countdown in Section 02, keep the day pages on your phone (and paper), and the trip runs itself: Vietnam's grand circuit, Laos' royal calm, and a straight shot home from the Mekong to Doha. Safe travels — 4 December is 45 days away.